people are scared of," says Singh of her character. Saxena calls her the "Sherlock Holmes" of the show. The actor says it was one of the toughest shoots for her, which entailed shooting in dense jungle at night. "It talks about man-vs-nature conflict and who can really win, and about human behaviour and how we adapt to situations," she adds.

Few have experienced the kind of fame on the small screen that Singh has. *Jassi...* (2003-06) was a phenomenon, with Singh dressing up and talking like the bashful, geeky Jassi for nearly three years. It was almost a double-edged sword, for audiences didn't know what the real Mona Singh looked like. "After the show, I was sure of one thing, that I didn't want to be remembered as a one-show wonder actor," she says. "I had to do something else and didn't want to get into another daily." She finally broke out of character after she appeared in—and won—season one of the dance reality show *Jhalak Dikhla Jaa*. After a big screen debut in *3 Idiots* (2009) and a few more shows acting and hosting, she took a hiatus from TV in 2014. "I just couldn't find the right show.... The quality was going down. Why be part of something that I'm not happy about?" she says. Until she found what she was looking for, Singh hosted corporate shows, acted on stage, and travelled.

Kaala Paani, in which **Mona Singh plays a doctor and researcher**, is one of the first shows to be shot extensively in the Andamans

The OTT rise couldn't have come at a better time for Singh, as it essentially became a ticket to freedom from the monotony of the daily show. What also helped were the parts coming her way. "It's not just a positive woman or someone who is vulnerable, naïve, doesn't know what to do and is helpless and constantly crying and praying for help as we normally see on TV," she says. Streaming changed the landscape, she notes, by showcasing characters with flaws and "layers".

She played one of them in *Made in Heaven*, a headstrong woman brought into the wedding planning business to put the books in order. If there was a consensus about season two despite its flaws, it was that Singh was the best new character and one with the most interesting graph as her character juggles between office and a family crisis. "It was crazy validation, like 'you stole the show and how, ate the cake and left no crumbs'," she says. Singh also messaged the show's co-creator, Zoya Akhtar, for choosing her, and the filmmaker in turn was glad she said yes.

It's what Singh has been doing a lot lately, much to the chagrin of her two pet dogs who have been missing her back in Mumbai. Ask her how many releases she has lined up next year, and she replies with a wide grin—six. She won't comment, but word is that one of them is Aryan Khan's directorial debut, a series tentatively titled 'Stardom'. "I'm so greedy right now that I don't want to say no," she says. At this rate, sought-after, busy actors on streaming will be referred to as the Mona Singhs of web series. ■

Suhani Singh





PLAY IT AGAIN, SAMI
Manning the camera on the sets of *Asteroid City* and *Poison*

stories by Roald Dahl—*The Wonderful Story of Henry Sugar*, *Poison*, *The Swan*, and *The Ratcatcher*—starring names such as Ben Kingsley, Ralph Fiennes, Benedict Cumberbatch, Dev Patel, Benoît Herlin, and more. Asked what went on behind the scenes to achieve the screen perfection that we see in *Henry Sugar*, Sami says, "Since it's semi-theatrical, we had set pieces moving, along with the camera and actors moving through spaces while we had sets being reorganised around them in camera! So, there's a lot of coordination required between the actors, the art department headed by Adam Stockhausen, the grip department headed by me, the lighting, etc. It's like a very, very complicated dance."

Sami, who believes in doing projects with people he enjoys working with, has a great working relationship with Anderson. "Wes and I are good friends, but very different people, which is maybe why we work well together. He comes up with a certain way he wants to shoot, which has never been done before, and I come up with a way to do it. And then the method is incorporated into his grammar of storytelling. I feel the two of us have evolved together over the 18 years we've worked together."

Contrary to what one might believe, all his work for every Anderson film is done using some of the oldest school technology. "Nothing we use on a Wes film is something that was invented in the last 20 years," Sami laughs. "We use a lot of complicated rigging, but it's all very analogue. We use film cameras, not digital, old hydraulic lift cameras, regular dolly tracks, Steadicam...Wes likes doing things the way they've always been done. The way he writes his films and the way he wants his camera moved is the best way to do it actually, because of the precision involved." ■

Priya Pathiyan